

altairsim — Graphics on CADzilla: the drawing demo

2026-10-01 · e650f94

drawdemo shows every drawing command of CADzilla's HD63484 ACRTC graphics processor, one screen for each command. It runs under CP/M 2.2 on an 8" floppy.

```
cd examples/cadzilla
altairsim drawdemo.toml
```

The machine boots itself to the CP/M prompt. Type **DRAWDEMO** :

```
56K CP/M 2.2b v2.3
For Altair 8" Floppy

A>DRAWDEMO

CADzilla drawdemo: the ACRTC drawing commands, 1024x768, 8 bpp

1/21 DOT - random dots placed by AMOVE; border dots stepped
        by RMOVE
Press any key for the next screen (ESC quits)...
```

On a build with **SDL3**, a 1024x768 window opens and comes to the front. The console tells you what each screen shows.

- Press any key for the next screen. A key typed in the window goes to CP/M, the same as a key typed in the terminal.
- Press **ESC** or **Ctrl-C** to stop drawdemo and go back to **A>**.
- Press **Ctrl-E** (STOP) to go to the monitor at any time. Type **RUN** to continue.

On a **headless** build, the machine runs the same program and draws nothing.

Two speeds

Machine file	Speed
<code>drawdemo.toml</code>	Full speed. The processor runs as fast as the host can run it. Each ACRTC command is complete as soon as it arrives, so each screen appears at once.
<code>drawdemo-real.toml</code>	The speed of the real hardware. A 2 MHz 8080 in real time, and each ACRTC command takes the time that the HD63484 data sheet gives. The filled shapes and the <code>PAINT</code> screen take visible time to draw.

The two files use the same disk. `drawdemo-real.toml` starts from `drawdemo.toml` and changes two settings: `cpu0 clock_hz = 2000000` and `cad0 draw_rate = "real"`. You can also change them at the monitor with `SET cpu0 clock_hz=2000000` and `SET cad0 draw_rate=real`.

The 21 screens

	Command	What it draws
1	<code>DOT</code>	Single pixels, placed with <code>AMOVE</code> and <code>RMOVE</code>
2	<code>ALINE</code>	Absolute lines
3	<code>RLINE</code>	Relative lines
4	<code>ARCT</code>	Absolute rectangles
5	<code>RRCT</code>	Relative rectangles
6	<code>APLL</code>	Absolute polylines
7	<code>RPLL</code>	Relative polylines
8	<code>APLG</code>	Absolute polygons
9	<code>RPLG</code>	Relative polygons
10	<code>AFRCT</code>	Absolute filled rectangles
11	<code>RFRCT</code>	Relative filled rectangles
12	<code>CRCL</code>	Circles
13	<code>ELPS</code>	Ellipses
14	<code>AARC</code>	Circular arcs, absolute and relative (<code>RARC</code>)
15	<code>AEARC</code>	Elliptical arcs, absolute and relative (<code>REARC</code>)
16	<code>PAINT</code>	Area fill to an edge color, solid and with a pattern
17	<code>PTN</code>	The pattern RAM, drawn as a picture
18	<code>AGCPY</code>	Graphic copy, absolute and relative (<code>RGCPY</code>)
19		The eight operation modes (OPM)
20		The color modes (COL), line styles and pattern zoom
21		The area modes (AREA): clip, hole and stop

The machine

`drawdemo.toml` is the built-in `cadzilla` machine with the parts that CP/M needs added:

- An 8080 processor, an 88-2SIO for the console at port `10` , and 56K of RAM.
- The **CADzilla** board at ports `70 - 77` , set to a 1024x768 monitor. `drawdemo` sets the ACRTC for 1024x768, so the board's `mode` must agree.

- An 88-DCDD floppy controller at port `08` , with the disk in drive 0.
- The DBL boot PROM at `FF00` . `RUN FF00` is the whole startup, as on a real disk Altair.
- The host bridge at port `B0` , for `R` , `W` and `HDIR` .

The disk

`cpm22b23-56k-drawdemo.dsk` is the CP/M 2.2b v2.3 56K system disk, changed to make room for `drawdemo`. That disk had 18K free, and `DRAWDEMO.COM` is 18K. These files were removed:

- `MBASIC.COM`
- the BASIC programs that need it: `LUNAR.BAS` , `STARINS.BAS` , `STARTRK.BAS` and `TICTAK.BAS`

The disk now has `DRAWDEMO.COM` and 60K free. All the other programs are still on it: `ASM` , `LOAD` , `DDT` , `M80` , `L80` , `ED` , `PIP` and the host-bridge utilities `R` , `W` and `HDIR` .

Drive 0 is read/write, as on a real machine. Nothing restores the disk after CP/M writes to it. Make a copy of the image before you test writes.

`DRAWDEMO.HEX` is the Intel HEX file of the program. CP/M's `LOAD` makes `DRAWDEMO.COM` from it. `DRAWDEMO.ASM` is the source.